region, there was not a single moment where we did not witness people pouring in to join the Yatra. Some people came in search of solutions for their problems; others came looking to ease or share their pain; and some came to just catch a glimpse of Rahul Gandhi or the other leaders. People cheered us from atop their terraces and windows, from the gates of factories, schools, colleges and hospitals, and from outside temples, gurdwaras, mosques, churches and monasteries. It was like the whole of India had been waiting for the Yatra. The Yatra and the yatris became part of their lives, much in the same way that their trials and tribulations became part of us. Those who believed in the ideals and values of the Yatra were obviously part of it, but I think that even those who opposed and ridiculed it were part of it in their own way.

Although it is difficult to summarize a journey of five months and spanning thousands of kilometres in a few pages, I have tried my best to share them with you. However, what is even more difficult for me is to share the immense knowledge I received during this time and the impact that the Yatra has had on me. But there are some lessons I wish to share, without which this account will be incomplete.

First, as we traversed across the country the discomfort of the discipline and the pains of the blisters on our feet were replaced by sheer amazement. It is easy to read in a book or to say that India is a beautiful, multicultural nation of people, but it is a completely different experience to actually see and absorb it. Our culture, food, languages and beliefs may look different, but they are all connected by the flow and acceptance of common ideas and thoughts. Otherwise, we would not find the statue of Bihar’s leader Babu Jagjivan Ram in Andhra Pradesh or B.R. Ambedkar’s statue in Jammu. This country is not just a connected mass of land—it is, in the truest essence, a connected land of ideas and emotions.

This brings me to the second learning, rather relearning, of the fact that the most significant idea and emotion that connects us all is love. One way in which people often came to show their love and support was by bringing us food. Sometimes we got home-cooked idlis, sometimes poha and sometimes parathas. Across the country, the flavours of these dishes surely